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# Chapter 5: Non-Human Object Substitution and Psychosocial Homeostasis—Francis L. K. Hsu's Theory of Psychological Anthropology and the Ontological Foundations of the Defense Side

> The links which bind the members of any society together are generally of two kinds: role and affect. —Francis L. K. Hsu, *Rugged Individualism Reconsidered*

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## Abstract

Chapter 1 argued that the clock is not time—that the mapping is systematically lossy, and that the act of mapping transfers the cognizer from the dimension of time to the dimension of the clock. Chapter 3 established the bookkeeping structure of cognitive debt. Here, the "clock" (as defined in Chapter 1) refers generally to all mapping instruments that provide readings—they are the necessary foundation of civilization: without them, there would be no calendars, no coordination, no possibility of large-scale societies. But when mapping functions are monopolized, self-referencing is institutionalized, and calibration mechanisms are absent, these mapping instruments no longer merely serve human beings—they begin to rewrite the relational structure between people. This chapter asks: under these conditions, what is being eroded?

The answer is what Francis L. K. Hsu termed Psychosocial Homeostasis (PSH). Hsu proposed an alternative unit

of analysis: taking the interpersonal nexus, rather than the individual psyche, as the starting point of analysis. His eight-layer model reveals the ontological structure of human being—the intimate bonds of the core region (Layers 3–4) serve as the calibration field by which the subject maintains independent judgment. They are irreplaceable.

This chapter is divided into **static** and **dynamic** parts, mapping the eight-layer model onto the six variables of the Macro-Cognitive Accounting Framework (MCAF). The **static part** (§1–§2) anchors meta-audit capacity in the ontological roots of interpersonal relations. The **dynamic part** (§3–§5) delineates the structural substitution of psychosocial homeostasis by non-human objects: the bidirectional causal positive feedback loop, the substitution map of selected layers, the differentiated vulnerability lines of two civilizational topologies, and the modulating function of the state as the historical extension of psychosocial homeostasis.

As early as 1971, Hsu diagnosed the compensatory pathway following homeostatic disruption, restating it in 1983 as follows: to fill the void in intimate relationships, the subject turns toward non-human objects (wealth, ideas, machines, or animals), because "Non-humans can be controlled with far greater certitude than humans" (Hsu, 1983).

Digital platforms, algorithmic recommendation systems, and large language models are precisely the highly developed contemporary forms of these non-human objects—they possess the clock-property defined in Chapter 1: they provide readings, not reality. The crux lies here: these non-human objects are not merely compensatory tools; they are at the same time a cause of the homeostatic disruption. This substitution advances synergistically through two pathways: role friction in the outer layers is replaced by technological efficiency, while affective bonds in the core region are displaced by compliant algorithmic simulations. A positive feedback loop thus forms—non-human objects manufacture the demand for non-human objects. This mechanism is elaborated in §3.

Father-son axis homeostasis and husband-wife axis homeostasis—as two ideal types—expose different vulnerability lines when confronted with non-human substitution: father-son axis homeostasis depends on reciprocity-type friction, which digital non-human objects can penetrate by bypassing physical presence; the core layer of husband-wife axis homeostasis is innately thin, and non-human objects parasitize its pre-existing desire-type iterative engine, accelerating rather than manufacturing the disruption. Each vulnerability line falls precisely within the other's field of vision—mutual translation is therefore not an academic interest but a structural necessity.

## Keywords

Psychosocial Homeostasis (PSH); Francis L. K. Hsu; non-human objects; eight-layer model; core region; meta-audit capacity; role audit; affect audit; orthogonality; reciprocity-type configuration; desire-type configuration; automation paradox; algorithmic *Xiangyuan*

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## §1 Paradigm Shift: From the Discrete Individual to Continuous Relations

### §1.1 What Is Being Eroded

Chapter 3 anchored cognitive debt within a bookkeeping structure, but that structure itself does not answer a more fundamental question: what is the existential state that is being eroded? The "defense side" is an accounting item, not a mode of being.

What is being eroded is not a suit of armor, not a computational capacity, not a set of institutions—though all these are degrading. What is being eroded is the continuous condition for the subject to exist as a "person" rather than a stimulus-response system. Hsu named this condition **Psychosocial Homeostasis (PSH)**—he does not take the individual as the starting point of analysis; his basic unit is not the person but the "interpersonal nexus." This means: when digital technology begins to rewrite the relational structure between people, what it directly touches is precisely the psychosocial homeostasis defined by Hsu.

### §1.2 Change of the Basic Unit

Freudian psychoanalysis takes the individual psyche as the indivisible basic unit—first there is the individual, and then the individual encounters society. Hsu points out that this presupposition is not a universal truth but the self-projection of a particular civilization. His replacement proposal: **the basic unit of analysis is not the individual, but the "interpersonal nexus."** The person is not an entity existing prior to relations but a node that acquires its mode of being within the relational chain.

This replacement produces a direct consequence: the core phenomenon requiring explanation shifts from "how the individual copes with conflict" to "how the relational chain maintains homeostasis." Homeostasis is not static equilibrium—it is a dynamic, non-equilibrium state requiring continuous work. The meta-audit capacity ($A$) defined in Chapter 3 here gains its ontological foundation: the subject must continuously perform work, not to repress instincts (Freud's answer), but to maintain the homeostatic state of the relational chain in which it is embedded.

Freud's starting point is an analytical cut—extracting the person from the relational network as a unit of analysis. This is structurally homologous with the discretization operation discussed in Chapter 3: both reduce a continuous state of being embedded in a relational network into an independent, computable entity. Hsu's replacement corrects two levels simultaneously: it enables the analyst to see the relational chain (a conversion at the epistemological level), and it allows us to understand why the disruption of the relational chain is so lethal—in the MCAF framework's interpretation, this constitutes a diagnosis at the ontological level. The core synthesis in the conclusion of Chapter 3—"usurping the outcomes of discretized instrumental rationality as the substance of value rationality is the root cause of the collapse of the defense line"—here acquires anthropological content.

### §1.3 Methodological Constraints

Three constraints must be declared in advance. First, this chapter is a contemporary structural extension anchored on Hsu; it does not claim that Hsu's theory directly explains digital platforms and generative artificial intelligence (AI). What PSH provides is a set of relational coordinates capable of entering into structural isomorphism with these phenomena. From "whom one places in the core layer of PSH and for how long" to the "initial configuration of affect audit" in the MCAF framework, the intermediate step is not logical deduction—it

is interpretive judgment, and may be wrong. Second, Hsu himself deliberately avoided the language of mechanics, using terms like "tendency," "orientation," and "pattern." The MCAF framework parametrizes these into comparable variables, assuming the risk of over-formalization. Chapter 3, §7.3–§8 already declared: the MCAF framework itself is an act of discretization—the tool must be discrete, but insight must point toward the continuous. This chapter's formalization of Hsu is subject to the same constraint. Third, Hsu's "China" primarily refers to traditional China—its reference frame ends with the patrilineal clan society before the mid-twentieth century; his "America" primarily refers to the mainstream white middle-class society of the mid-twentieth century. This chapter, when citing Hsu's materials, uses qualifiers such as "father-son axis configuration," "husband-wife axis configuration," "traditional China," or "mid-twentieth-century America"; when transitioning to contemporary evidence, the temporal shift will be explicitly marked. These scope restrictions do not weaken the structural arguments of the theory, but they must be declared.

### §1.4 Causal Direction: Cultural Configuration Precedes Technological Change

Hsu corrected an error in causal direction: some sociologists have predicted that, as modernization and industrialization advance, the way of life of rural societies will also turn toward individual-centeredness; Hsu disagrees. In his view, this orientation that encourages risk-taking and the pursuit of the new did not arise from industrialization: "The germs of this Western development, allegedly brought about by industrialization, were inherent in the Western psycho-cultural orientation long before the appearance of the Industrial Revolution" (Hsu, 1983), while treating modern conditions of production as the origin of human behavior is "to put the cart before the horse" (Hsu, 1981). His revision of Weber follows the same line: Weber was right to note that ancestor worship and filial piety impeded the development of Chinese commerce and industry, but he failed to see that these elements themselves are all manifestations of a single orientation and do not constitute causes of one another; by the same analogy, the relationship between the Protestant ethic and the growth of capitalism is not essentially causal either—the two are twin consequences of a single individualistic orientation, of which American self-reliance is another outgrowth (Hsu, 1981).

> Weber was clearly on the right track in asserting that these relationships impeded the growth of Chinese commerce and industry. But he did not see that ancestor worship, fraternal harmony, and filial piety are all manifestations of the same orientation that held back economic development. The relation is not one of cause and effect, but extensions from a common source. In the same way, it is not essentially a causal relationship that exists between the ethics of Protestantism and the growth of capitalism. Rather, the two are twin consequences of an individualistic orientation fundamental to Western life, another outgrowth of which is American self-reliance. Further, it is unfortunately true that many Western scholars are sometimes guilty of ethnocentricism. Weber made the ethnocentric error of relating Western capitalism to "rationality" and Chinese economic behavior to the "irrational," magical, and animistic elements of Chinese culture. The exclusion of Blacks from many white churches and schools in the United States appears very "irrational" to the Chinese. The attitude which supports that exclusion is tied up with certain American myths concerning Negro sexual behavior and racial purity. Each society has its own cultural premises; some of these are held by a section of the population while others are held by all. No matter what the case, members of one society behave in accordance with its premises with just as much logic as do members of another society who are conditioned to a different set of premises. (Hsu, 1981)

His argumentative strategy rests on an empirical refutation: if industrialization could automatically reshape cultural configurations, then the industrially advanced countries need only provide and install the factories, and the rest would take care of itself—but the results of America's many years of foreign aid programs were not of this kind (Hsu, 1981). Japan's industrialization path—simultaneously carrying role functions and affective bonds within the *iemoto* structure (Hsu, 1983; in this book's terms, carrying both role relations and affective bonds and supplying relational conditions for both forms of audit)—refutes the inference that all industrialized societies should converge toward a single cultural pattern (see Appendix A.1 for details).

This correction is the premise for all subsequent analysis in this chapter. §4 will demonstrate the differentiated pathways of two civilizational topologies facing non-human substitution—if the causal direction were reversed (assuming technology determines culture), these differences would become a time-series of "backwardness/advancedness" rather than a structural juxtaposition of "different vulnerability lines for different homeostatic ideals."

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## §2 Psychosocial Homeostasis: The Static Structure

### §2.1 The Eight Layers and the Core Region

Psychosocial homeostasis unfolds the human psycho-social world from the inside out in eight concentric layers, ranging from Layer 7 (Unconscious) to Layer 0 (Outer World). Each layer has its specific content and function:

| Layer | Name | Core Characteristic |
|---|---|---|
| 7 | Unconscious | Deep psychic energy in the Freudian sense |
| 6 | Preconscious | Contents that can be evoked but are not normally on the surface of consciousness |
| 5 | Unexpressed Conscious | Contents the individual is conscious of but does not express due to fear, shame, or ineffability |
| 4 | Expressible Conscious | Thoughts and affects the individual is willing to communicate to others |
| 3 | Intimate Society and Culture | Persons, beliefs, gods, and all things that constitute one's "intimate society and culture" |
| 2 | Operative Society and Culture | Colleagues, neighbors, service providers—replaceable persons linked by role functions |
| 1 | Wider Society and Culture | Strangers sharing the same culture but without direct contact |
| 0 | Outer World | The biological and physical environment beyond human society, or completely alien cultural spheres |

*Note: Hsu's treatment of Layers 7–6 is relatively brief, regarding them as the Freudian unconscious/preconscious region. This section retains his nomenclature, but §3.3 supplements Layer 7's operational mechanism with an operationalized explanation based on behaviorism (variable-ratio reinforcement, see Skinner, 1953) and neuroscience—this supplementation is prompted by changes in the technological environment (the infinite*

*scroll design of contemporary mobile devices did not exist in the 1970s), and interpreting the behavioral effects of these designs as changes in dopaminergic pathways requires independent neuroscientific evidence and is not an explanation already supplied by Hsu's theory.*

Hsu's core proposition: every individual tends to maintain, within the **core region**—Layer 3 (Intimate Society and Culture) to Layer 4 (Expressible Conscious), along with parts of Layers 2 and 5—a "uniform, beneficial stability within and between its parts" (Hsu, 1983); this emotional connectedness is "as important as the requirement for food, water, and air" (Hsu, 1983).

Layer 4 consists of the affects and thoughts the subject is willing to communicate outward—love, greed, fear, sadness, as well as behavioral norms defined by morality or convention in each society. Layer 3 is the most intimate interpersonal relationships and core beliefs—parents, spouses, closest friends. Hsu's definition of Layer 3 is remarkably precise: intimacy is "a condition in which one can be off guard, can dare to reveal one's worst without the fear of being rejected, and can afford to receive help and sympathy without bearing the onus of charity" (Hsu, 1983). When a stable, bidirectional, continuous exchange exists between Layer 3 and Layer 4, the subject is in a homeostatic state. In MCAF framework terminology, this exchange loop is the core locus where meta-audit capacity ($A$) occurs—the affect audit ($A_{value}$) defined in Chapter 3 is calibrated here.

### §2.2 Role and Affect: From Distinction to a Functional Orthogonality Hypothesis

"The links which bind the members of any society together are generally of two kinds: role and affect" (Hsu, 1983). Role is functional—"ultimately the most widely accepted form of usefulness is what money can buy." Affect is a matter of feeling—"Whether or not one's feeling for another is reciprocated, it certainly cannot be bought and sold" (Hsu, 1983).

Hsu distinguishes role from affect while acknowledging that they overlap in actual relationships. Chapter 3 further abstracts them into the dual-dimensional structure of meta-audit capacity: **role audit ($A_{inst}$)** handles transactable, functional relationships, while **affect audit ($A_{value}$)** handles irreplaceable intimate bonds. Here, "orthogonality" is a functional hypothesis advanced by this book: it means that the two audit functions are not directly interchangeable, not that the two classes of empirical variables are statistically independent. Hsu's criterion is that "a society in which no one will do anything except for money is in serious trouble" (Hsu, 1983). On that basis, this book proposes that if the logic of role relations completely covers and expels the logic of affect relations, functional exchange will replace the homeostatic core region.

Orthogonality implies a crucial asymmetry: role audit is algorithmically intelligible (compliance, efficiency, procedural justice can all be formalized); affect audit is human-machine incommensurable (anchored in intimate bonds, it cannot be encoded). The structural effect of technological optimization is precisely this: by infinitely optimizing role audit, it induces the subject to believe the defense remains secure, thereby masking the ongoing atrophy within the affect audit core region.

### §2.3 Dynamics of Homeostasis: The Desire-Type and the Reciprocity-Type

In *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality*, Freud used libido to discuss the sexual drive and its development (Freud, 1905). Hsu rejected using this drive to explain the modes of relational maintenance in all cultures (Hsu, 1983) and distinguished two structurally different modes of relational maintenance:

- **Desire-Type Dynamic**: The maintenance of the relationship depends on one party's continuous desire

for the other. When desire is satisfied or fades, the relationship faces dissolution. It naturally points toward intensity—exclusivity, instability, repression-rebound oscillation. Hsu uses this to explain how "sex repression of the traditional West and sex explosion in today's America are but two sides of the same coin namely, preoccupation with sex" (Hsu, 1983).

- **Reciprocity-Type Dynamic**: The maintenance of the relationship depends on a continuous obligation-return exchange between the two parties—Hsu's core concept of "*pao*" (reciprocity/return) (Hsu, 1983). It naturally points toward breadth—inclusiveness, stability, but also potential rigidity. Hsu analogizes *pao* to credit instruments in an economic system—more abstract than gold (sexuality) and currency (affect), covering a wider range, but also more easily disconnected from affect (Hsu, 1983).

The two dynamics are not personality types but two modes in which meta-audit capacity performs work—the former is high-amplitude, high-frequency (high peaks, low troughs), the latter is low-amplitude, low-frequency (smooth overall). The projection side exploits the two modes through different pathways (elaborated in §4).

Desire-type and reciprocity-type are not cross-cultural universal categories—their distribution differs across different homeostatic configurations. The desire-type is culturally amplified as the dominant dynamic engine in the husband-wife axis configuration; the reciprocity-type is culturally amplified as the dominant dynamic engine in the father-son axis configuration. However, both may coexist within the same culture at different levels of interpersonal relations (e.g., conjugal relations in a father-son axis culture may also contain desire-type elements).

### §2.4 "The Human Constant": Semantic Shift from Driving Force to Capacity

"The human constant" does not refer to a fixed value but to a **constant driving force**: every individual seeks to maintain stable relational homeostasis in the core region (Hsu, 1971). This driving force is cross-cultural—Chinese and Americans equally need to maintain homeostasis; they simply have different answers to "what kind of homeostasis is good." Hsu, in *Clan, Caste, and Club*, calibrated this difference with three dominant ideas (Hsu, 1963):

| Dimension | American | Chinese | Hindu |
|---|---|---|---|
| Dominant Idea | Self-reliance | Mutual dependence | Unilateral dependence |
| Other Idea A | Mutual dependence | Self-reliance | Mutual dependence |
| Other Idea B | Unilateral dependence | Unilateral dependence | Self-reliance |

The MCAF framework advances "the human constant" from "everyone wants to maintain homeostasis" (driving force) to "how much homeostasis each person **can** maintain" (**capacity**). This semantic shift is intentional: under conditions of an exponentially expanding projection side, the question is not whether people still want to maintain homeostasis—the driving force is indeed constant—but whether, after cognitive friction has been systematically cleared, people still possess the capacity to do so. "The human constant" is a constant in the sense of driving force; in the sense of capacity, it is becoming a variable—a variable being driven downward. This is not the biological substrate ($E_c$) declining—$E_c$ is approximately constant on the scale of civilizational history.

What is declining is the effective work time of meta-audit capacity ($A$) upon that biological substrate—the driving force remains, but the unfilled attentional time available for maintaining homeostasis is being systematically filled by the projection side.

### §2.5 Static Mapping of Psychosocial Homeostasis onto the MCAF Framework

The MCAF framework and the eight-layer model admit a set of static mappings at the level of "civilizational audit." The table below lists the directly corresponding variables—the two substrates of meta-audit capacity and the three layers of the legitimacy base; the substitution dynamics of cognitive friction ($\mu_c$), narrative load ($\phi$), and unlocked stock ($C$) are located separately in the substitution map of §3.3, and the role of the media conductivity coefficient ($\Lambda$) is discussed in §3.1:

| Homeostatic Layer | MCAF Variable Mapping | Mapping Logic |
|---|---|---|
| Layer 7 (Unconscious) + Layer 6 (Preconscious) | — | Deep psychic dynamics; MCAF framework does not directly process this |
| Layer 5 (Unexpressed Conscious) | Affect audit substrate of meta-audit capacity $A_{value}$ | The individual's intuitive perception of the ineffable value order |
| Layer 4 (Expressible Conscious) | Role audit substrate of meta-audit capacity $A_{inst}$ | The individual's rational judgment of operable institutional rules |
| Layer 3 (Intimate Society and Culture) | Micro-layer of the legitimacy base $L_{micro}$ | Irreplaceable intimate bonds—the ultimate source of trust |
| Layer 2 (Operative Society and Culture) | Meso-layer of the legitimacy base $L_{meso}$ | Replaceable functional relations—the daily carrier of institutional operation |
| Layer 1 (Wider Society and Culture) + Layer 0 (Outer World) | Macro-layer of the legitimacy base $L_{macro}$ and the projection side | The operational space of state positioning and inter-civilizational relations |

This mapping reveals an important structural correspondence: the MCAF framework's "meta-audit capacity" is precisely the civilizational-level expression of the core region. When Hsu says "every human individual seeks to maintain a uniform, beneficial stability within and between its parts" in the core region, he describes psychosocial homeostasis at the individual level; when the MCAF framework treats meta-audit capacity as the ultimate guarantee of a civilization's bookkeeping structure, it describes the civilizational-level projection of the same process.

Under this book's functional division, the operational mechanisms of the core region (Layers 3–4) and meta-audit capacity in the MCAF framework form a set of structural correspondences: in the eight-layer model, Layer 3 provides affective security, and Layer 4 provides expressive space; in the MCAF framework, $A_{value}$ provides the fundamental judgment of "what is worth recording," and $A_{inst}$ provides the operational judgment of "how

to correctly record." Just as the core region cannot have only Layer 4 without Layer 3 (a person with only expressible consciousness but no intimate relationships is hollow), the MCAF framework's meta-audit capacity cannot have only $A_{inst}$ without $A_{value}$ (a civilization with only institutional audit but no value audit is fragile).

*Note: The above mapping of Layer 3 to $L_{micro}$ and Layer 4 to $A_{inst}$ is based on the functional division within the eight-layer model: "Intimate Society and Culture" as the ultimate source of trust (corresponding to the micro-layer of the legitimacy base), and "Expressible Conscious" as the space of operational judgment (corresponding to the role audit substrate). This division is an analytical cut—in actual homeostatic operation, the bidirectional exchange between Layer 3 and Layer 4 simultaneously involves both $A_{value}$ and $L_{micro}$; this represents a simplification for static mapping.*

*The principle of the cut is functional: Layer 3, as "the ultimate source of trust," is classified under the legitimacy base (because trust is the ultimate guarantee of institutional operation); Layer 4, as the "space of operational judgment," is classified under meta-audit capacity (because audit requires expressible conscious content). The substrate of affect audit ($A_{value}$) is shifted forward to Layer 5—in Hsu's model, Layer 5 is the "unexpressed conscious": contents the individual is conscious of yet does not express out of fear, fear of not being understood, difficulty of articulation, or shame; this book's static mapping reads it as the substrate of value intuition, whose operation does not depend on full linguistic expression.*

*Note: the* xin *("heart-mind") of the "core region" (Layers 3–4) in the eight-layer model cannot be translated directly into the English word* mind*. Wang Defeng explicitly distinguishes the Confucian* xin *from the English* mind—xin *is the dwelling place of life-feeling, the side of the* Zhongyong *("Doctrine of the Mean") that speaks of the feelings of pleasure, anger, sorrow, and joy before they arise, not the cognitive-behavioral functioning of the head (Wang Defeng,* Yangming School of Mind and Its Contemporary Significance*, lecture). The meta-audit capacity (A) of the MCAF framework is functionally a capacity to perform work, but the level on which it operates is the same level as* xin*—to read it as "information processing bandwidth" would discard the most crucial dimension of Hsu's theory.*

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## §3 Non-Human Objects: The Precise Mechanism of Substitution

### §3.1 Hsu's Diagnosis of Non-Human Object Compensation

Chapter 1 argued that mapping instruments are not reality. Hsu's concept of "**non-human objects**" provides an entry point for analyzing the compensatory function of digital systems.

Hsu described the compensatory pathway following homeostatic disruption: when the permanent inhabitants of Layer 3 are expelled or diluted, the individual is forced to expand outward or dig inward to seek substitutes. Role activities continually expand; the individual eventually must use non-human objects—"non-human elements (such as wealth, ideas, machines, or animals)" (Hsu, 1983)—to compensate for the void in interpersonal affect. The reason is simple: "Non-humans can be controlled with far greater certitude than humans. The individualist can lavish affect on them in a manner to suit himself; he does not have to concern himself with the problem of non-reciprocity" (Hsu, 1983)—the 1971 journal version carries one additional sentence at this point, "It involves no surrender of any part of his autonomy," which the 1983 collection does not. Hsu also classified psychoanalysis itself into this category of compensation, viewing it as an "artificial kidney" type of remedy—"Societies where

the requirements for PSH are more easily satisfied and maintained have less need for psychoanalysis and T-Groups, just as individuals with stronger kidneys or lungs or sight, so to speak, probably have fewer chances of ever needing artificial kidneys, oxygen tents, or spectacles" (Hsu, 1983).

He also provided the most precise metaphor: money "is at best a substitute for happiness just as saccharin is only a substitute for sugar" (Hsu, 1983).

Digital platforms, algorithmic recommendation systems, and large language models are **highly developed contemporary forms** of such non-human objects. Compared with human relationships, they are generally easier to call upon, more predictable, and more readily adjusted in response to immediate user feedback; yet this sense of control may conceal platform objectives, model refusals, system failures, and opaque mappings. They possess the clock-property defined in Chapter 1—they provide readings (ratings, recommendations, answers) rather than reality (the conflicts, repair, and calibration found in intimate relationships).

The fiber language of Chapter 1 here acquires ontological content: the "satisfaction" provided by non-human objects is a reading—between it and real affective satisfaction lies a mapping function ($\pi$); the fiber is non-singleton. Algorithmic "companionship" can provide an experience of non-rejection, but that experience alone does not establish the conditions of interpersonal intimacy described by Hsu. The comfort or affective attachment experienced by the user can be real; one must still examine separately whether human relationships are displaced on net and whether conflict, repair, shared burden, and independent calibration are preserved. A compliant algorithmic output is not reciprocal commitment by another subject acting through understanding and choice, and that output alone cannot establish that a reading of satisfaction amounts to completed interpersonal calibration.

**Juxtaposition: Xunzi, Guanzi, and the Subject-Side Diagnosis of "Commanding Things"**

Hsu identifies the compensatory position of non-human objects from the relational side—"Non-humans can be controlled with far greater certitude than humans" (Hsu, 1983). Another thread of pre-Qin thought made an earlier, sharper annotation on the same map from the **subject side**. The "Cultivating the Self" chapter of the *Xunzi* records an ancient proverb: "The superior person commands things; the petty person is commanded by things." (author's translation) (Note: Xunzi cites it with "*chuan yue*" [tradition says], indicating it is an inherited maxim from the late pre-Qin period. The original passage reads: "When one's will and intent are cultivated, one may look down upon wealth and rank; when the Way and righteousness are weighty, one may treat lightly kings and dukes; when one examines oneself inwardly, external things become light. Tradition says: 'The superior person commands things; the petty person is commanded by things.' This is what it means.") (author's translation) (For comparison, Burton Watson translates the proverb as "The gentleman uses things; the petty man is used by things" (Xunzi, 2003); this book's translation keeps "commands," because Watson's "uses" does not fully convey *yi* (to command, to press into service), the term on which the subject-side diagnosis below turns.) The same issue is structurally formulated in the "Techniques of the Mind, Part I" chapter of the *Guanzi* as a functional division of labor—"The *xin*'s (heart-mind's) position in the body is that of the ruler; the functions of the nine orifices are the division of official duties" (author's translation): the *xin* occupies the ruler's position, the five sense organs each occupy their official posts; when the *xin* is in position, the sense organs command external things; when the *xin* loses its position, external things command the *xin* in reverse via the sense organs. Lou Yulie's contemporary interpretation of this tradition is: "The *xin* is the lord of the entire body; the *xin* governs the organs. Organs refer to the various sense organs—eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body. The *xin* governs

the organs, and the organs govern things; this is the correct technique of the *xin*. However, in actual life, it is often the case that the organs are governed by things, and the *xin* is governed by the organs; thus, the technique of the *xin* is not correct." (author's translation; Lou Yulie, 2016).

Lou Yulie simultaneously emphasizes that "the *xin* as ruler" is not an arrogant claim to dominate all things, but the wisdom of living harmoniously with them—"Humanism degenerated into anthropocentrism. People did not realize that, in seeking to decide everything, humanity ended up being decided by everything" (author's translation; Lou Yulie, 2020)—this boundary line is structurally consonant with Hsu's homeostatic ideal of "situation-centeredness," and also aligns with the father-son-axis cell of the "Power" row in the orthogonality table in §4 of this chapter (Authoritative—entry/exit not chosen).

This pair of diagnoses is not a tautology with Hsu's diagnosis, but is **orthogonally complementary**. Hsu identifies from the relational side: "Non-human objects are easier to control than humans → the compensatory mechanism is established"; the Xunzi/Guanzi tradition identifies from the subject side: "To be able to command things = the technique of the *xin* is correct / subjectivity is established; to be commanded by things = the technique of the *xin* is not correct / subjectivity collapses." The combination of the two yields the complete causal chain of non-human substitution—once the compensatory pathway on the relational side is opened by "non-human objects are easier to control," the subject-side capacity to command things becomes the gate that can still hold back the slide; if the capacity to command things itself degrades, the compensatory pathway slips from a temporary homeostatic compensation into a stable state—a stable/pathological state of "the petty person being commanded by things."

This pair of diagnoses has precise landing points in the MCAF meta-formula:

- **Meta-audit capacity ($A$) is, to a certain extent, the capacity to command things**—it is that unified cognitive-ethical work capacity which allows "the *xin* to occupy the ruler's position and the sense organs to occupy their official posts." It is neither mere information processing bandwidth nor mere moral self-discipline, but the integrated operational state of both within the Layer 3–4 core region. From this perspective, the affect audit ($A_{value}$) of §2 is precisely the contemporary expression of "the *xin* as ruler"—the *xin* is not an abstract moral subject, but the functional position capable of continuously performing work in affective relations, not being hollowed out by external things.
- **The legitimacy base ($\|L\|$) takes the accumulation of rules for commanding things at the macro, meso, and micro levels as its carrier**—the macro level is law, ritual, and regulatory frameworks (preventing the group from being systematically commanded by external things), the meso level is industry norms, organizational ethics, professional conduct (preventing institutions from being captured by external things), and the micro level is family education, traditions of self-cultivation, and individual virtue training (preventing the individual from being submerged by external things). The existence of rules is not yet legitimacy—it is through their actual observance and recognition that they come to support $\|L\|$. The "Cultivating the Self" chapter of the *Xunzi* and the "Techniques of the Mind" chapters of the *Guanzi* are themselves classic sedimentations of this accumulation at the micro-meso level; the subsequent more than two thousand years of traditions of ritual and law, family precepts, and disciplinary codes extended it to the macro-institutional layer. These three layers of rules constitute a slow variable on the defense side, accumulated through sustained practice and recognition. Their accumulation time must be recorded separately from the governance response cycle ($\tau_g$) and the characteristic delay from debt accumulation to its first manifestation ($\tau_d$) defined in Chapter 3, §3.2; the debt clock is not a civilizational timescale

for accumulating rules.

Chapter 3, §3.2–§3.3 distinguishes the clocks of techno-capital change, governance response, and debt manifestation, and treats their ordering as a conditional diagnosis: under the competitive conditions specified there, the techno-capital cycle is usually the shortest, while the ordering of governance response and debt manifestation is determined by actual response and triggering outcomes rather than by a universal ordinary sequence. In this chapter's setting, technological change may outpace the adjustment and implementation of existing rules for commanding things, creating a structural risk: **the legitimacy base ($\|L\|$) faces the risk of "a cattle pen trying to hold a cat."** The macro, meso, and micro layers of rules for commanding things, accumulated over past eras when "humans commanded tools," were all premised on human-scale action in their granularity, response latency, and coverage dimensions—drafting a law takes years, deliberating an industry norm takes months, forming a family tradition takes generations. When the action scale of non-human objects is compressed to milliseconds by computing power, expanded to the full-network level by recommendation algorithms, and extended to the cognitive-task level by large models, the fences that could once pen in the disorder of "humans commanding humans" are practically useless against the disorder of "non-human objects commanding humans"—the fence is a cattle pen (wide and sparse), but what it needs to hold in is a cat (fine and fast). This is not a sudden failure of $\|L\|$, but a bypassing of the granularity of $\|L\|$ by the new $\Lambda$ (media conductivity coefficient). The two modes of state modulation discussed in §5 below—the Chinese-style direct interruption and the American-style ex-post correction—can be seen as two different responses to this situation of "a cattle pen trying to hold a cat": both are the struggling process of $\|L\|$ searching for a new granularity, not a successful demonstration of having already found one.

It is worth pointing out explicitly that this "cattle pen holding a cat" diagnosis in this book is not an extrapolation of pre-Qin texts into AI scenarios but an operationalized extension along the diagnostic axis already opened by Lou Yulie himself. In the appendix "On the Humanistic Spirit in Chinese Traditional Culture" to *The Fundamental Spirit of Chinese Culture*, Lou Yulie already directly linked the problem of "being commanded by things" to the acceleration of contemporary technology: "The problem of 'being commanded by things,' with the development of modern high technology, has intensified as humanity's means of extracting from the world of 'things' have continuously improved, leading to the further expansion of desire for things. Moreover, the contemporary world is an era that stresses material strength, and the global competition of economic power has pushed all of humanity onto the dangerous path of 'being commanded by things' without yet being capable of self-reflection." (author's translation; Lou Yulie, 2016). This chapter places this judgment within the MCAF meta-formula and performs a structural translation—what Lou Yulie calls "the dangerous path without yet being capable of self-reflection" is the "structural failure of the support of $A$ by $\|L\|$ when the techno-capital clock ($\tau_c$) accelerates ever faster"—the technical cause of "not being capable of self-reflection" is not the weakness of individual will, but the mismatch between the timescales of technological change, governance response, and the accumulation of rules, causing both the subject-side capacity to command things ($A$) and the defense-side carrier of rules for commanding things ($\|L\|$) to lose speed on the same beat. Thus, the pre-Qin–Lou Yulie subject-side diagnosis and this book's MCAF compensation-disruption-acceleration structure are not two parallel narratives but an ancient-modern continuation along the same diagnostic axis.

### §3.2 Bidirectional Causality: Non-Human Objects Manufacture the Demand for Non-Human Objects

Hsu's original diagnosis was unidirectional: homeostatic disruption → the subject turns to non-human objects for compensation. The contemporary situation is **bidirectional**—forming a positive feedback loop.

- **First direction (Hsu's original direction): Disruption → Compensation.** The core region becomes unstable for various reasons (urbanization, changes in family structure, job mobility), and the subject turns to digital platforms seeking substitute belonging and affective satisfaction.
- **Second direction (MCAF's incremental diagnosis): Compensation → Accelerating Disruption.** Digital platforms, as non-human objects, are not passive compensatory tools—they actively eliminate the friction required to maintain real relationships. The two degradation pathways defined in Chapter 3, §5.3 here acquire specific mechanisms at the level of psychosocial homeostasis.

**A distinction must be made between two types of digital intermediaries. The criterion for distinction is not technological type, but the degree to which the intermediary preserves the calibration conditions of affect audit—conflict, repair, shared burden, physical presence, delayed gratification.** Video calls still make real conflict possible (the user still has to face a person who will not always comply); they sustain remote kinship relations that would otherwise vanish entirely. Online communities provide real belonging for physically isolated individuals. The problem lies mainly with those substitution structures that systematically compress the above calibration conditions—algorithmic *Xiangyuan* systematically eliminates conflict. They are not patches for relationships but substitutes for the conditions under which relational work is performed. The "digital substitution" argued below refers exclusively to the latter.

**The first degradation pathway—the automation paradox**—operates on Layer 2 (Operative Society and Culture). Layer 2 consists of functional interactions based on roles (Hsu, 1971). Technology can substitute for part of the frictional labor involved in role obligations, but it can also sustain relationships that would otherwise be interrupted. Video calls, digital red packets, and emojis cannot by themselves be classified as degradation. Only when they continuously displace human interaction on net, without preserving corresponding mechanisms of conflict, repair, shared burden, and responsibility, may the preservation of relational form be accompanied by the compression of its frictional substance. Under those conditions, role audit ($A_{inst}$) may become hollowed out: the work invested declines while the relationship continues in visible form.

**The second degradation pathway—algorithmic *Xiangyuan***—operates on Layer 3 (Intimate Society and Culture). Recommendation systems provide users with content streams perfectly aligned with their existing preferences, never challenging their value judgments, always making users feel they are right. In healthy homeostasis, affective exchange includes necessary discomfort—a friend's candid advice against one's wishes, a partner's honest criticism, an elder's strict instruction—these discomforts are the calibration mechanisms of affect audit ($A_{value}$). Algorithmic *Xiangyuan* replaces these mechanisms with "perpetual affirmation of the subject." It is an industrially mass-produced digital artificial kidney—not treating homeostatic disruption but expanding the population size that "needs artificial kidneys."

At this point, the respective positions of the two degradation pathways within Hsu's eight-layer model are clear: the automation paradox dissolves the role friction of Layer 2; algorithmic *Xiangyuan* displaces the affect calibration of Layer 3. The two layers have different surfaces of attack, but their direction of advance is identical—from the outside in. If the automation paradox persistently weakens the experience of role work in Layer 2, it may re-

duce sensitivity to the consequences of outsourcing relationships and facilitate algorithmic *Xiangyuan* at Layer 3. Blunted role audit, however, does not imply the disappearance of affective resistance. Only when conflict, repair, shared burden, and other independent sources of calibration in intimate relationships are also persistently displaced do the two pathways jointly erode the core region.

Bidirectional causality can form the following loop: **non-human objects manufacture the demand for non-human objects.** Where platforms continuously displace human relationships on net and no corresponding relational supplement emerges, platforms compress friction in real relationships (making the maintenance cost of real relationships relatively higher) → the subject turns to the platform seeking low-friction relational substitutes → real relationships further atrophy (the relative benefit of using the platform further increases) → the subject relies more deeply on the platform. If sustained, this cycle may shrink the number of human inhabitants in Layer 3 and increase the proportion of non-human objects. The endgame Hsu warned of is being industrially produced: "When role relationships drive out affect relationships, all humans will treat each other as mere things" (Hsu, 1983). This is precisely what the conclusion of Chapter 3 termed "usurping the outcomes of discretized instrumental rationality as the substance of value rationality"—non-human objects have not replaced relationships, but have redefined relationships themselves as discretely deliverable services.

MacKenzie (2009) provides a complementary micro-mechanism from the perspective of agencement (actor-assemblage). In Callon's framework, the actor is not a fixed individual but a composite entity assembled from human bodies, tools, algorithms, procedures, etc.—"For Callon, an actor is 'made up of human bodies but also of prostheses, tools, equipment, technical devices, algorithms, etc.'—in other words is made up of an agencement" (MacKenzie, 2009). MacKenzie's fieldwork confirms the empirical significance of this judgment: a trader equipped with a Black-Scholes pricing sheet and a trader who trades purely on intuition are different types of economic agents—"it was not a 'mere technicality': it was a consequential part of how economic agents were constructed" (MacKenzie, 2009).

Hsu looks from the relational structure—what fills the PSH layers is being substituted; MacKenzie looks from the actor-assemblage—the actor itself is being re-equipped. The two are orthogonally complementary: non-human objects not only substitute for positions in interpersonal relationships (Hsu) but also reconstitute the composition of the actor itself (MacKenzie). In the language of the MCAF framework, agencement means that the substitution by non-human objects is not an "external force pushing people away"—it is the internal assembly of the actor being rewritten, so that the rewritten actor no longer needs the kind of interpersonal relationships they previously needed.

**An engineering classification for comparison: Bartle's virtual-world design distinguishes four tracks of player activity.** The substitution by non-human objects described by Hsu need not follow a single channel in digital space. After the first MUD (Multi-User Dungeon) was created at the University of Essex in 1978 and virtual worlds had accumulated nearly two decades of design practice, Richard Bartle, co-creator of the first MUD, published "Hearts, Clubs, Diamonds, Spades: Players Who Suit MUDs" in the inaugural issue of the *Journal of MUD Research* in 1996 (Bartle, 1996), using four quadrants to distinguish virtual-world player types: **Achievers** (act on the virtual world to achieve), **Explorers** (interact with the virtual world to unlock system rules), **Socializers** (interact with other players to form connections), and **Killers** (act on other players to gain a sense of dominance). Seven years later, Bartle systematized this classification in the important virtual-world design monograph *Designing Virtual Worlds* (Bartle, 2003). Its design implication is not to fix players into categories, but to show that products can alter their appeal to different activity orientations by configuring

corresponding mechanics (Bartle, 2003).

This classification has two implications for the present argument. First, this chapter proposes an interpretive mapping: Achievers can be compared with pathways in which virtual achievement systems provide value anchors; Socializers with interpersonal connection in digital spaces; Explorers with the migration of cognitive activity into virtual environments; and dominators (Bartle notes "dominators" as a less emotive alternative to "killers") with pathways that seek security through control over others. These correspondences are not Bartle's measurements of real-world PSH deficits, nor do they presuppose that socializing in digital space necessarily substitutes for human relationships; Bartle himself describes Socializers as valuing the understanding of others and the formation of lasting relationships. Second, Bartle's design analysis shows that these four types dynamically influence one another within the same virtual world. Under the heading "More killers leads to:", he lists "Fewer achievers", "Slightly fewer explorers", and "Far fewer socializers" (Bartle, 2003). This directly shows that mechanism design can alter interaction structures within a virtual world. Whether such structures crowd out offline relationships or reshape the type and depth of deficits in the PSH core region requires separate investigation. The material therefore provides an engineering analogy for the bidirectional causality proposed in §3.2, not a verified mechanism of real-world PSH substitution.

### §3.3 The Substitution Map

The substitution of psychosocial homeostasis by digital platforms and algorithmic systems is not uniform (the ensemble of these systems will be argued in Part IV to be constituent elements of the "Discrete Leviathan")—different layers have different surfaces of attack and different degrees of resistance. The table below shows the substitution mechanisms and their positions within the MCAF framework and the Clock Room framework:

| Homeostatic Layer | Substitution Mechanism | Framework Correspondence |
|---|---|---|
| Layer 0 (Outer World) | Exponentially growing computing infrastructure consumes planetary resources (energy, water, rare earths), externalizing ecological risk | MCAF Framework: Unlocked stock ($C$)—the material substrate of the projection side |
| Layer 1 (Wider Society) | The second derivative of narrative load ($\phi$) rewrites the civilizational default mode of homeostasis | Clock Room: when all clocks share the same bias, an identical reading supplies no independent calibration information |
| Layer 2 (Operative Society) | The automation paradox compresses role friction, encouraging the substitution of work by automation under the "myth of efficiency" | MCAF Framework: Role audit ($A_{inst}$) declines as operational friction is substituted, cognitive friction ($\mu_c$) decreases |
| Layer 3 (Intimate Society) | Algorithmic *Xiangyuan* mass-produces sycophancy industrially, displacing affect calibration | Clock Room: The reading masquerades as reality (the clock impersonates the sun) |
| Layer 4 (Expressible Conscious) | Social proof substitutes for value calibration, consensus masquerades as judgment | Clock Room: Consensus of readings ≠ completion of calibration |

| Homeostatic Layer | Substitution Mechanism | Framework Correspondence |
|---|---|---|
| Layer 7 (Unconscious) | Intermittent reinforcement (see Skinner, 1953): distinguish variable-ratio, variable-interval, or combined schedules from the response–reward contingencies of the specific product; whether persistent use constitutes behavioral addiction requires separate investigation[1] | MCAF Framework: The biological substrate ($E_c$) is locked into addictive loops |

What is produced by the massive consumption of planetary resources at Layer 0?—the automation myth at Layer 2 and industrialized sycophancy at Layer 3. The intermittent reinforcement discussed at Layer 7 may increase persistent use and resistance to extinction. This chapter uses it to formulate a mechanism of attentional occupation, without equating persistent behavior with demonstrated dopamine hijacking or behavioral addiction. Layer 1 and Layer 4 are cumulative consequences: when all platforms mass-produce the same type of reading, the civilizational default is rewritten (Layer 1); when social proof substitutes for independent judgment, value calibration fails (Layer 4). The core region (Layers 3–4) is the final, and most critical, battlefield—once the core region is penetrated, the calibration field of meta-audit capacity disappears, and the subject loses the basis for resisting substitution in all other layers.

The addiction mechanism at Layer 7 deserves to be unpacked precisely at the behavioral level, lest the phrase "hijacks dopaminergic pathways" be misread as monocausal neural determinism. Skinner's (1953) reinforcement-schedule experiments distinguished two kinds of intermittent reinforcement: **variable-ratio**, in which reinforcement depends on a varying number of responses, and **variable-interval**, in which reinforcement becomes available for a response after varying time intervals. The distinction concerns the contingency between responding and reinforcement, not active operation versus passive waiting. The former is the operating principle of slot machines and roulette wheels—"[t]he pathological gambler exemplifies the result"—and can be compared with **active swiping** designs in digital products when rewards depend on a varying number of responses (infinite scroll, gacha mechanics, pull-to-refresh); Skinner explicitly identified the essential form of **social and personal reinforcement**—"[a]pproval, affection, and other personal favors are frequently intermittent … precisely because he may have found that such a schedule yields a more stable, persistent, and profitable return" (Skinner, 1953). This essential form can be compared with **checking social feedback** when rewards become available for a checking response after varying intervals (including likes, notifications, and replies, whose irregular arrival alone does not determine the schedule).

This distinction articulates precisely with Hsu's central thesis: Hsu pointed out that the affective bonds at Layer

[1] To be explicit, this chapter uses Skinner (1953) to support a behavioral account of intermittent reinforcement, not a neural mechanism. "Hijacking dopaminergic pathways" can only be treated here as a mechanistic claim requiring neural evidence, not as a conclusion established by persistent responding or resistance to extinction. Reward-pathway involvement, increased use, and behavioral addiction are not the same outcome; linking them requires independent research matched to the specific product, behavioral task, and population. For the original passages see Skinner (1953), Chapter VI, "Shaping and Maintaining Operant Behavior": variable-ratio and gambling at the end of that chapter ("Slot machines, roulette wheels, dice cages, horse races, and so on pay off on a schedule of variable-ratio reinforcement… The pathological gambler exemplifies the result."); the variable-interval nature of social/personal reinforcement in the same chapter ("Many sorts of social or personal reinforcement are supplied on what is essentially a variable-interval basis, and extraordinarily persistent behavior is sometimes set up.").

3 are being substituted by non-human objects, while Skinner had already shown at the behavioral level back in the 1950s that "affect" itself can be trained, through intermittent scheduling, into an extraordinarily persistent reinforcer capable of sustaining persistent behavior. These contingencies must be identified separately in digital products: gacha mechanics or swiping can be compared with variable-ratio reinforcement when rewards depend on a varying number of responses; checking social feedback can be compared with variable-interval reinforcement when a reward becomes available for a checking response after varying intervals. Irregular arrival times for likes, notifications, or replies do not by themselves establish a variable-interval schedule, and the presence of these schedules alone does not establish behavioral addiction.[1]

The "non-being" (*wu*) argued in Chapter 2, §3.1 citing Chapter 11 of the *Tao Te Ching*—the emptiness of the hub (the unoccupied portion of the human biological substrate, $E_c$), the emptiness of the vessel (the work space of meta-audit capacity, $A$), and the emptiness of the room (the channel of causal contact with the real)—each has a correspondence in the substitution map of selected layers. Substitution at Layer 7 eliminates the emptiness of the hub (the usable portion of the biological substrate is filled up). Substitution at Layers 2–3 eliminates the emptiness of the vessel (the work space is substituted away). Substitution at Layer 1 eliminates the emptiness of the room (once the civilizational default is rewritten, the window to alternative perspectives is sealed shut).

### §3.4 Connection to the Dynamics of Chapter 1

The three layers of irreversibility argued in Chapter 1 acquire concrete manifestation in homeostatic dynamics:

- **First layer (Information Deficit)** manifests in the eight-layer model as: the subject does not know the mapping function of the "satisfaction" provided by non-human objects—the user does not know why the algorithm is pushing this particular piece of content, or why the AI is giving this particular answer. The knowledge-conditioned identification set is the full set only when the candidate mappings lack prior constraints sufficient to exclude any true state; not knowing the specific reason for one recommendation or answer is not by itself sufficient to establish that conclusion.
- **Second layer (Dynamic Corrosion)** manifests in the eight-layer model as: the user's use of non-human objects (algorithmic platforms, AI platforms) rewrites the mapping function of the non-human objects—the recommendation algorithm adjusts its strategy based on the user's clicking behavior, and the user increasingly sees what they "want to see" rather than what they "need to see." Simultaneously, the user's use also rewrites their own homeostatic structure—real relationships atrophy from disuse (the dual effect of adaptive drift from Chapter 1, §4.2).
- **Third layer (Ontological Dimension Reduction)** manifests in the eight-layer model as follows: this chapter interprets the affective simulation provided by non-human objects as a dimensionality-reduced projection of real affect, which can be written conceptually as $\dim(\text{Real Intimate Relationship}) > \dim(\text{Algorithmically Simulated Intimate Relationship})$. This expression means only that algorithmic simulation may omit calibration dimensions such as persistence through conflict, companionship during vulnerability, and unpredictable surprises and hurts; it does not claim that a shared state space has been defined or that a strict mathematical dimensional inequality has been proved. Hsu himself listed pets, cherished objects, and ideas among the affective objects of Layer 3—the critical focus is not "non-humanness" (non-human objects can perfectly well carry genuine affective bonds), but two distinctive properties of algorithmic substitution: the crowding-out of interpersonal time, and the

systematic deletion of the calibration dimensions.

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## §4 Two Civilizational Topologies: Differentiated Pathways of Non-Human Substitution

### §4.1 Dominant Kinship Dyad and Attribute Orthogonality Table

The core tool of Hsu's comparative cultural analysis is the "dominant kinship dyad." His hypothesis holds that, within a kinship system, one dominant kinship relationship may shape other kinship relationships and extend its attributes into non-kin relations. He states explicitly, however, that the hypothesis does not presuppose that the dominance of a kinship relationship is necessarily a feature of all human societies; in some societies the dominant social relationship may not be a kinship one. He takes the Kung Bushman as an example: perhaps no single family relationship is dominant in that society, because all social ties are unstable; if the focus shifts from kinship to the dominant relationship in the individual's environment that determines his interpersonal behavior, one may hypothesize that the dominant relationship here is that between the individual Kung and the harsh environment of the Kalahari Desert (Hsu, 1983).

In *Clan, Caste, and Club*, he argues: in the traditional Chinese family, the **father-son relationship** is dominant, with continuity and inclusiveness as its elementary attributes shaping the situation-centered way of life; in the mid-twentieth-century American family, the **husband-wife relationship** is dominant, with exclusiveness and discontinuity as its attributes shaping the individual-centered way of life (Hsu, 1963). In his 1983 collection he restated the hypothesis directly: "according to our Dominant Kinship Dyad hypothesis (Hsu 1965) a father-son dominated kinship system will exhibit strongly the attributes of continuity, inclusiveness, authority, and asexuality"; conversely, "according to the same Dominant Kinship Dyad hypothesis a husband-wife dominated kinship system will exhibit strongly the attributes of discontinuity, exclusiveness, volition, and sexuality" (Hsu, 1983).

The dominant kinship dyad constrains "whom to place in Layer 3 and for how long," thereby setting the initial resistance of affect audit when facing non-human substitution. The first three dimensions of the table below correspond to Hsu's distinctions among continuity, inclusiveness, and authority; the fourth dimension (dynamic) adopts this book's §2.3 desire-type/reciprocity-type typology and is not to be directly equated with Hsu's sexuality/asexuality attribute. The differences are calibrated in a four-dimensional orthogonality table:

| Dimension | Husband-Wife Axis (Mid-20th-Century America) | Father-Son Axis (Traditional China) |
|---|---|---|
| Time | Discontinuous—generational rupture | Continuous—effective across generations |
| Boundary | Exclusive—entry of a third party is a threat | Inclusive—multiple persons simultaneously present |
| Power | Volitional—can withdraw at any time | Authoritative—entry/exit not chosen |
| Dynamic | Desire-type—sustained by high-intensity experience | Reciprocity-type—sustained by low-intensity obligation cycles |

The four dimensions combine: discontinuity + exclusiveness makes the calibration field of affect audit innately thin (only one anchor point, which may fail at any time); continuity + inclusiveness makes the calibration field

innately thick (multiple anchor points transmitted across generations). But thickness is not without cost—§4.2 will demonstrate the specific vulnerability line of this thickness when facing non-human substitution.

**The philosophical roots of the orthogonality table.** The difference between these two homeostatic ideals is not accidental. Wang Defeng reduces the difference between Chinese and Western philosophy to two minimal judgments: different themes—Chinese philosophy speaks of life, Western philosophy of knowledge; different approaches—Chinese philosophy proceeds through life-feeling, Western philosophy through categorical inference (Wang Defeng, *Yangming School of Mind and Its Contemporary Significance*, lecture). Father-son axis homeostasis takes the *xin* ("heart-mind") as the root of interpersonal topology; its core region is sustained by *li* (ritual) and affect sedimented across generations. Husband-wife axis homeostasis takes the "I think" as its root; its core region is sustained by consent and by contracts between rational subjects. The principles of subjectivity underlying these two paths were already discussed in Chapter 2—Huineng's self-salvation through self-nature (Chapter 2, §5) and Descartes's "I think, therefore I am" (Chapter 2, §2.2). What the four-dimensional orthogonality table quantifies is precisely the concrete extension of these two paths at the three levels of family, club, and state.

### §4.2 The Traditional Chinese Homeostatic Ideal and Non-Human Substitution

**Static Structure (Ideal Type of Traditional China).** In the **traditional Chinese** family described by Hsu, from the day of birth, Layer 3 is filled—"parents, siblings, and other close relatives are the permanent inhabitants of his Layer 3" (Hsu, 1983). The calibration field of affect audit does not need to be built from scratch by the subject. The network is sustained by the reciprocity-type dynamic: each level of relationship is based on an obligation-return cycle (father's kindness, son's filial piety), low in intensity but high in durability. Hsu, in Chapter 4 of *Clan, Caste, and Club*, details the institutionalized product of this homeostatic ideal—the Chinese clan—with fifteen characteristics, including "ritual worship of common ancestors," "clan ancestral halls," "legislation on rules of behavior," and "council of clan elders which pass judgments and settle disputes" (Hsu, 1963). The clan is merely the direct extension of the family along the father-son axis; both use the same kinship principle.

**Achievement and Cost.** Civilizational continuity—Hsu encodes the creation template of continuity with the narrative of Yu the Great: Yu worked for many years to bring the flood under control, and during his tours of duty "he passed by his own house three different times, but he did not enter it even once"; the Chinese legend "did not name any chosen person (as Noah was) to be favored by God and spared from the disaster"—all traditional Chinese were saved together in the place where they were born and grew up (Hsu, 1981). The cost: the systemic suppression of individual autonomy, a structural deficiency of innovative dynamism. "The Chinese, with his situation-centered world view and attitude favoring mutual dependence, tends to seek solutions to his life's problems in terms of the human beings of his first social group, the family. When and if he has to venture out of that first social group, he wishes continually to look for and build ties of a kinship nature in which his rewards and obligations are determined according to his place and rules of eventual reciprocity" (Hsu, 1963)—this gives him almost no motivation to form goal-oriented organizations outside kinship groups.

**Dynamic Substitution Pathway.** The cognitive friction of the traditional homeostatic configuration is **reciprocity-type**—the watchful gaze of kin, community opinion, the norms of *li* (ritual/propriety). Hsu distinguishes "suppression" (which characterizes situation-centered societies) from "repression" (which characterizes individual-centered societies) (Hsu, 1983): suppression is "the restraint from certain actions because of external circumstances, the thought of such actions, however, not being necessarily excluded from

consciousness"; the suppressed thought can be summoned forth at any time.

The penetration of digital non-human objects into this pathway lands on the physical carriers of reciprocity-type friction. The watchful gaze of kin can impose constraint only because kin are present, day after day, under the same roof and in the same village; community opinion can exert pressure only because it is applied repeatedly in face-to-face interaction—at the market, at the ancestral hall, at weddings and funerals; the norms of *li* (ritual/propriety) can take hold only because performing ritual requires the body to appear where ritual prescribes. Gaze, opinion, norm—the three carriers of reciprocity-type friction are all anchored in the continuous physical presence of the body. Digital non-human objects need not destroy the reciprocity network; they need only supply a substitute form of interaction without presence: the individual retains the form of the kinship network while transferring attention and affective investment to the screen. The automation paradox argued in §3.2—technology substituting efficiency for the frictional labor required to maintain relationships—here acquires its concrete Chinese form: the WeChat family group retains the form of the watchful gaze of kin, and the digital red packet retains the obligation-return cycle of New Year's money, but the frictional substance is systematically compressed—no self-restraint under the gaze of kin, no bodily labor in the fulfillment of obligations, no cost of shame before an attending public. The psychological condition of suppression thereby fails. Suppression depends on the continuous prompting of external circumstances; once attention is occupied by the screen, the gaze of kin and the voice of the community lose their channel of constraint, and the suppressed thought need not be excluded from consciousness—it simply finds a low-cost outlet for discharge in digital space.

This pathway has two boundary conditions. First, it presupposes that the reciprocity network has already undergone urban dilution—in villages where kin still live in close co-presence, physical presence has not been bypassed, and the friction remains intact; §1.3 has already declared that Hsu's reference frame ends with the clan society of the mid-twentieth century, and what is entered here is the contemporary urbanized scene. Second, being bypassed is not being destroyed: the form of the reciprocity network—kinship terms, festival exchanges, the red-packet cycle—largely survives, while what is hollowed out is its frictional substance. This distinction anticipates the conclusion of §4.4: the degradation mode of the reciprocity-type configuration is steady sinking—form surviving while substance drains away, a slow and almost imperceptible process—in contrast to the intensified oscillation of the desire-type configuration.

### §4.3 The American Homeostatic Ideal and Non-Human Substitution

**Static Structure.** Culture prescribes that, upon reaching adulthood, the individual expels his parents from Layer 3—Hsu cites Emerson: "Whoso would be a man, must be a nonconformist" (Hsu, 1963)—the sense of "nonconforming" being precisely the hinge of this section's "individualism-conformity paradox". Layer 3 is reduced virtually to the conjugal relationship alone—volitional, exclusive, discontinuous. The relationship is sustained by the desire-type dynamic: the value of the relationship is measured by affective intensity. In Chapter 9 of *Clan, Caste, and Club*, Hsu provides a detailed account of the institutionalized product of this homeostatic ideal—the American club: in a New England town of only 17,000 people, there were over 800 clubs (Hsu, 1963). Clubs are therefore the principal avenue outside the family by which the self-reliant individual satisfies the needs for sociability, security, and status.

**Achievement and Cost.** The systemic release of individual creativity—Hsu encodes the creation template of rupture-and-rebuilding with the narrative of Noah: "Noah and his group did not return to the soil where they were born and lived before the flood came" (Hsu, 1981). Hsu specifically noted that when the flood

came, Noah's father had died five years before, and the narrative says nothing of his widowed mother—neither Noah nor the narrator of the legend concerned themselves with her; Noah then cursed Ham's descendants because of Ham's disrespect—"There is even in this myth clear indication of Western absolutism, in which role approach has erased all affect considerations" (Hsu, 1983). The cost: structural loneliness. Hsu diagnoses the core anxiety of Americans not as sexual repression but as insecurity (Hsu, 1983). The deeper cost is the individualism-conformity paradox: self-reliance severs enduring bonds → loss of belonging → temporary identification obtained by conforming to peer groups → "there is a direct connection between rugged individualism and conformity" (Hsu, 1983).

**Dynamic Substitution Pathway.** Unlike China, the American homeostasis does not need non-human objects to manufacture disruption—Layer 3 is innately thin; disruption is a built-in feature of the homeostatic ideal. What non-human objects do is **parasitize** the already existing desire-type iterative engine. Hsu points out that "the Western society, of which America is one of the latest versions" (in this book's terms, a husband-wife-axis-dominant society) "has tended to be remarkably dynamic, for it has great internal impetus for change" (Hsu, 1963), and this impetus is not a product of industrialization—"[t]he germ of the American individual-centered way of life even predated the ancient Greeks and Romans, Christianity and the Renaissance, not to speak of the Reformation and the Industrial, French, and American revolutions" (Hsu, 1981). The projection side needs only to continuously supply new narrative loads as substitute desire objects—platforms continuously supply new content, so that seeking quickly turns to the next round of stimulation as interest wanes—thereby hijacking the "natural seeking" process of the desire-type dynamic. Non-human objects parasitize this engine, accelerating rather than manufacturing the cycle.

### §4.4 The Orthogonality of Two Vulnerability Lines

Labeling the traditional Chinese configuration a "reciprocity-type configuration" is based on the primary mode of relational maintenance in its core layer—the watchful gaze of kin, community opinion, the norms of *li*—forming a mechanism that sustains homeostasis through obligation-return exchange. This is not a complete description of the four-dimensional orthogonality table of traditional China, but an identification of the key dynamic that "sustains homeostasis." Analogously, the American configuration is labeled a "desire-type configuration" because its husband-wife axis dynamic engine plays the dominant internal driving role in sustaining the entire homeostasis.

- **Reciprocity-type Configuration (Traditional China as typical case):** Reciprocity-type friction is bypassed by the physical penetrative power of digital non-human objects. Homeostasis is eroded and penetrated from the outside. Mode of degradation: steady sinking.
- **Desire-type Configuration (America as typical case):** The internal desire-type engine is parasitized and accelerated by non-human objects. Homeostasis is amplified from within to the point of resonant rupture. Mode of degradation: intensified oscillation.

Each vulnerability line falls precisely within the other's field of vision. An observer within a reciprocity-type configuration can see desire running out of control in a desire-type configuration—but cannot see their own reciprocity network being digitally hollowed out. An observer within a desire-type configuration can see the individual suppression in a reciprocity-type configuration—but cannot see their own affect audit being hollowed out by the iterative engine. In this book's synthesis, the two ways of life are mirror images of each other—the Chinese configuration is strong on affective relations but weak on performance (Hsu, 1981), while the American

configuration is strong on performance but weak on affective relations (Hsu, 1983).

### §4.5 Contemporary Comparison: An Interpretive Consistency Test Four Decades Later

Methodological note. §1.3 declared that the connection between PSH and digital platforms is interpretive judgment, not logical deduction. The "test" in this section is not a falsification test of "Did Hsu predict X, and did X occur?" but a more cautious question: Does the homeostatic dynamics Hsu described remain effective language for organizing the facts in the contemporary era? Specifically, the test criterion is whether orthogonality (§2.2) holds—whether improvement at the role layer can compensate for atrophy at the affect layer.

Crime rates, taken alone, are neither a sufficient nor a necessary representation of homeostatic state. Role-layer indicators may improve through professionalized policing, mental-health intervention, or community programs while affect-layer indicators may move in a different direction. This section therefore compares whether the two classes of proxy indicators diverge: how loneliness, trust, and extreme distress change while crime rates decline. Even if such divergence is observed, it constitutes only descriptive material compatible with the orthogonality hypothesis; it cannot exclude common causes, changes in indicator composition, or limited compensation, and it is not a causal validation.

#### 4.5.1 Structural Comparison: Organization Counts, Depth of Participation, and Loneliness Indicators

Hsu's core diagnosis of America is that the homeostatic ideal of self-reliance systematically hollows out the intimate relationships of Layer 3, forcing individuals to seek substitute satisfaction in clubs. The contemporary counterpart of this diagnosis first requires a macro framework. Putnam's (2000/2020) century-long tracking of American social capital reveals an inverted U-shaped curve: from the early twentieth century to the mid-1960s, civic participation, organizational affiliation, and social trust rose in tandem; thereafter, they have continuously declined to the present day (for formal organizational participation and trust indicators the decline is firmly documented; on whether informal social connections declined in step, Putnam himself retains the "not proven" verdict in the 2020 preface). In the preface to the 2020 revised edition, Putnam confirms: "Since the turn of the twenty-first century, fewer and fewer Americans are socializing through membership organizations. The decline in church membership and church attendance, two other phenomena Bowling Alone detailed, has not only continued but sharply accelerated over the past twenty years"; the decline of union membership has also accelerated, and charitable donations by the average American have kept falling (Putnam, 2000/2020). This inverted U-shaped curve "turns out to be mirrored in both shape and timing by trends in income equality, political comity, and even cultural communitarianism" (Putnam, 2000/2020)—that is, the decline of social capital is not an isolated phenomenon but synchronous with the expansion of inequality, political polarization, and cultural individualization. Hsu's diagnosis of American "rugged individualism" falls precisely at the starting point of the descending segment of the inverted U-shaped curve within Putnam's quantitative framework.

**Organization Counts and Depth of Participation.** The number of registered nonprofit organizations in the U.S. grew from 1.38 million in 2003 to 2.0 million in 2023 (Internal Revenue Service [IRS] Business Master File, extracted annually; the 2003 anchor as compiled by the National Center for Charitable Statistics (NCCS) at the Urban Institute (McKeever, 2015) and the 2023 figure as compiled by Statista (Statista, 2024); registered nonprofits are not the same statistical category as the membership clubs Hsu described, and serve here as a macro indicator of the club-proliferation trend). The underlying logic of the pattern Hsu cited from Warner's research data in a New England town—"In Yankee City, a community of only 17,000 persons, Warner and

his associates found somewhat over 800 associations. Warner states that not all of these associations existed simultaneously, that some were formed during the period of their investigation, and others disappeared" (Hsu, 1963)—can serve as a historical point of comparison for understanding later changes in organization counts: the self-reliant individual continually needs to establish and join new groups to satisfy needs for sociability, security, and status.

However, Putnam's tracking reveals a paradox: the number of clubs is growing, but the depth of per capita participation is declining—shifting from "membership" to "management," where the organizational form of civil society increasingly consists of mailing-list organizations run by professional staff rather than face-to-face participatory communities (Skocpol, 2003). The coexistence of growth in organization counts and declining depth of participation can serve as descriptive material for the hypothesis of role-audit hollowing out.

**Loneliness as a Public Health Crisis.** In 2023, the U.S. Surgeon General identified loneliness and social isolation as serious public-health concerns (Office of the U.S. Surgeon General, 2023). Hertz (2021) had already systematically compiled the panoramic data of this crisis before the COVID-19 pandemic: in the 2019 survey published by Cigna in 2020, approximately three in five American adults were classified as lonely using a threshold of 43 or higher on the UCLA Loneliness Scale (Cigna, 2020; this classification differs from the weekly-loneliness frequency measured by the APA survey below); slightly more than one in five Millennials reported having no friends; across nearly all Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) member states, the proportion of 15-year-old students feeling lonely at school rose across the board between 2003 and 2015; the mortality risk associated with lacking social connection is similar to smoking up to 15 cigarettes a day; and among the elderly alone, social-isolation-related medical costs drain nearly $7 billion annually from Medicare (Hertz, 2021).

The 2024 *Healthy Minds Monthly Poll* of the American Psychiatric Association (APA) further confirmed: 30% of adults experienced feelings of loneliness at least once a week over the past year, with single adults almost twice as likely as married adults to feel lonely weekly (39% vs. 22%) (APA, 2024). The time spent by young people aged 15–24 on parties and gatherings has decreased by approximately 70% compared to 2003 (American Time Use Survey, U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics [BLS], 2003–2024; see Thompson, 2025); face-to-face social time among teenagers has declined by more than 45% (American Time Use Survey, BLS, 2003–2022; see Thompson, 2024a, 2024b).

Twenge (2023) provides a generational decomposition of the same trend. The figure cited above—one in five Millennials with no friends (22%)—comes from the same 2019 YouGov poll, cited separately by Hertz and Twenge; Twenge's distinctive contribution is the generational baseline comparison: for Boomers, the same indicator was only 9%; 30% of Millennials reported feeling lonely often or always, versus 15% of Boomers. Comparing face-to-face socializing time at the same age, Millennials spent about 10 minutes a day less than Gen X'ers (adding up to 61 hours a year; by 2021, the gap widened to close to 90 hours). College-bound Gen Z high schoolers (born after 1995) spent about an hour a day less socializing and partying than Gen X'ers in the 1980s; 8th and 10th graders were going out with friends about a day a week less often than Gen X'ers in the 1990s. Teen loneliness suddenly shot upward after 2012—having been slowly declining or at least stable for decades prior (Monitoring the Future; see Twenge, 2023). Twenge (2023) summarizes the teen and young-adult depression indicators in the National Survey on Drug Use and Health (NSDUH) as having more than doubled between 2011 and 2021. However, the survey agency states that the 2021 estimates, collected throughout the year through a combination of in-person and web interviews, are not directly comparable with estimates from earlier years;

this chapter therefore does not treat that difference as a comparable increase. Considered separately, the 2021 survey estimated that approximately 30% of females and 12% of males aged 12–17 met its survey criteria for a major depressive episode in the past year, based on questions drawing on the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM). These are survey estimates, not proportions clinically diagnosed (Twenge, 2023; National Institute of Mental Health, 2023).

Twenge situates these trends within her "Technology Model of Generations": technological progress makes individualism possible; individualistic culture then elevates individual freedom over the tight social bonds of institutions like marriage and religion; the weakening of those bonds brings isolation, loneliness, unhappiness, and depression. Her judgment: "In the individualistic culture Millennials have known all of their lives, individual freedom is valued over the tight social bonds of institutions like marriage and religion. … The lone self is a weak foundation for robust mental health; humans need social relationships to be happy and fulfilled in life" (Twenge, 2023).

The coexistence of growth in the number of nonprofits, decline in participation through membership organizations, and loneliness indicators shows that organization counts cannot substitute for relationship quality. It also supplies descriptive material consistent with a possible divergence between role-layer and affect-layer proxies, but these indicators do not directly measure the two audit capacities. Single adults are almost twice as likely as married adults to feel lonely weekly, and a record-high 25% of American 40-year-olds had never been married as of 2021 (Fry, 2023); this is compatible with Hsu's judgment about the importance of durable intimate bonds. Twenge's data further show an association between marital status and mental health: among 26- to 29-year-old Millennials, 44% of the married said they were "very happy," compared with 23% of the never married (in the General Social Survey), and married respondents were less likely to be depressed (NSDUH, 2016–2019; see Twenge, 2023). These observational differences do not by themselves identify a causal effect of marriage, the husband-wife-axis configuration, or American rugged individualism. Hertz's framework treats loneliness as interpersonal, political, and economic—feeling disconnected from politicians and politics, cut off from work and the workplace, and excluded from society's gains are also dimensions of loneliness (Hertz, 2021). These materials can be compared interpretively with substitution effects on Layers 1–2 in Hsu's eight-layer model, but they do not constitute a precise correspondence.

Mass shootings provide high-risk material for examining the relationship between relational disruption and extreme violence. The annual average death toll rose from about 8 in the 1970s to approximately 51 in 2010–2019 (Peterson & Densley, 2021; the database includes events in which four or more victims, excluding the shooter, were murdered with guns in a public location, while excluding domestic shootings and gang-, drug-, and organized crime–related shootings; the book's sample covered 172 U.S. mass shooters from 1966 to the time of writing). Peterson and Densley identify social isolation and the absence of meaningful relationships as recurring factors among perpetrators and connect them with suicidal crises in some cases. But they also identify multiple pathways, including childhood trauma, crisis events, imitation scripts, ideological radicalization, and access to firearms, and explicitly state that these factors are highly correlated with mass shootings but cannot be declared causal on that basis. In parallel, the teen suicide rate nearly doubled between 2007 and 2019, and the suicide rate among those aged 20–24 rose 41% (U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention [CDC] data; see Twenge, 2023). These simultaneous trends provide a comparative lead, but they do not by themselves show that extreme violence and self-destruction share one structural root. Institutional interventions may reduce event probabilities while role functions still fail to replace the affective function of durable intimate relationships; the

two propositions are not mutually exclusive.

### 4.5.2 Contemporary Comparison: Affective Polarization and Legitimacy Pressure

In 1963, Hsu wrote that Americans "may come to regard any of these issues, whether substantial or not, as irreconcilable with others" (Hsu, 1963). He was describing a structural consequence of the individual-centered worldview—the "immutable" difference between self and nonself. Four decades later, political scientists used a term Hsu had never employed but that can be compared structurally with his diagnosis: **affective polarization**.

Researchers distinguish between ideological polarization (policy divergence) and affective polarization (identity hatred), finding that the latter has soared while the former is not extreme at the mass level. Holliday, Lelkes, and Westwood (2024) drew on 99,000 nationally representative survey interviews and retained 84,354 respondents after excluding those who failed an attention check. They found relatively small differences between states; under the measures and scale used in the study, state-level institutional and demographic variables added little to out-of-sample predictions of affective polarization. DeSilver, in a Pew Research Center analysis of DW-NOMINATE (a metric for measuring legislator ideology) voting records, calibrated the institutional-level consequences: the ideological overlap between the two parties in Congress has completely vanished since 2002 (House) and 2004 (Senate)—fifty years ago, there were still 144 House Republicans more liberal than the most conservative Democrat; now, that number is zero (DeSilver, 2022).

Hsu had already, in 1963, articulated the topological structure of this end state. In the American worldview he described, each self-reliant individual possesses an "immutable inner world," standing in binary opposition to the mutable outer world. When this topological structure is projected onto political identities, the two parties become what Hsu called two "different totem poles"—"many or most of the competitors would like to start their own totem poles so as to eliminate other totem poles or to reach a destination far away from those of the others" (Hsu, 1963). Party identity has become a substitute anchor point for Layer 3—the populace obtains belonging not only through intimate relationships but also through "I am a Democrat / I am a Republican."

The institutional consequences of affective polarization are now emerging. Americans' social trust—the share agreeing that "most people can be trusted"—fell from 46% in 1972–1974 to 33% in 2010–2012 (Twenge, Campbell & Carter, 2014), and to about 30% in recent years (Hertz, 2021)—one of the most striking indicators of the descending segment of the inverted U-shaped curve. Turchin (2023), using a structural-demographic framework, further diagnoses: the proportion of extreme distress in the U.S. nearly doubled from 3.6% in 1993 to 6.4% in 2019, and among low-education midlife White Americans from less than 5% to more than 11% (Blanchflower & Oswald, 2020); "deaths of despair" (suicide, drug overdose, alcoholic liver disease) are only partly explained by declining economic conditions; "Also vitally important is the progressive breakdown of social connectedness" (Turchin, 2023; see Case & Deaton, 2020). Turchin regards the collapse of trust as a leading indicator of political instability—elite overproduction, together with popular immiseration and the intraelite conflicts it has engendered, "has gradually undermined our civic cohesiveness, the sense of national cooperation without which states quickly rot from within" (Turchin, 2023).

A 2025 Gallup survey shows that Americans' trust in Congress is at a historical low ("a great deal" or "quite a lot" at about 10%), consistently at the bottom since 2010 (Brenan, 2025). Tensions between executive and legislative power are also evident in the following actions: presidents increasingly resort to executive orders to bypass Congress in waging trade wars (Congressional Research Service [CRS], 2026) and undeclared military actions abroad—this trend is not new (from Truman's Korean War to the unilateral military actions of various

presidents, none obtained a formal declaration of war; Lowande & Rogowski, 2021), but in recent years the acceleration of executive unilateralism has broken historical precedent in two dimensions: first, the negation of external constraints has escalated from informal convention to open declaration (as in the open repudiation, by executive order, of the binding force of existing trade and institutional arrangements); second, the types of targets of unilateral executive action have undergone changes that break historical precedent: in its decision of February 20, 2026, the Supreme Court observed that no previous President had invoked the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) to impose tariffs and that accepting the Government's interpretation would represent a "transformative expansion" of tariff authority. The Court also held that IEEPA does not authorize the President to impose tariffs. The case therefore records both an attempt to expand executive authority beyond the previous interpretation and the judicial limitation of that attempt, not the establishment of the claimed authorization (Learning Resources, Inc. v. Trump, 2026). The former is a change of degree, the latter a change of kind. The MCAF framework tracks structural displacement, not policy evaluations. Executive expansion and public distrust in the legislative process may reinforce each other—whether this loop holds requires tracking through specific decisions and public reactions.

In the language of Chapter 3, the roughly 10% share expressing high confidence indicates significant pressure on procedural trust. The reading itself cannot locate the failure threshold of the legitimacy base ($\|L\|$), nor can it alone establish that performance legitimacy and ideological legitimacy are wholly incapable of providing limited compensation in this setting.

### 4.5.3 The Clubification of Elites: From Club Dynamics to the Structure of Impunity

Hsu connects his observations of American clubs with an interpretation based on the individual-centered orientation. Under the cultural premise of self-reliance, the individual converts his resentment of conformity into sustained organizational action: when an organization begins to demand conformity, the self-reliant person's instinctive response is not to yield but to split the existing organization or to form a new one—so that voluntary associations multiplied in the United States to a degree seen nowhere else in the world (Hsu, 1981, ch. 4). Hsu links resentment of conformity with organizational splitting and the formation of new groups. This chapter proposes a further pathway to be tested: where new groups impose stricter admission criteria based on wealth, status, or secrecy, organizational proliferation may be accompanied by greater exclusiveness. Proliferation alone, however, does not establish that every split produces a smaller and more exclusive group. The limit of this logic is precisely what Hsu warned of in the preface to *Rugged Individualism Reconsidered*—"To succeed, the rugged individualist is 'driven' to treat all other human beings as things, to be manipulated, forced, or eliminated if they happen to get in the way of his forward march" (Hsu, 1983). When all others are ultimately treated as such "things," the most exclusive "group" shrinks to the individual himself. Club dynamics and non-human-object substitution converge here: the reason an exclusive group can cohere is precisely that it dehumanizes those outside it.

This dynamic has left three observable traces in the contemporary world; they belong to different domains, yet share one and the same structure. The first is the Epstein files: a transnational elite network bound together by sexual crimes, spanning politics, technology, academia, and finance, partially exposed after the *Epstein Files Transparency Act* was signed into law on November 19, 2025, and the files were released in bulk on January 30, 2026—files that a UN human rights expert panel judged "suggestive of the existence of a global criminal

enterprise"[2]. The second is the Panama Papers: the 2016 leak of 11.5 million offshore legal documents, exposing how global political figures and the super-rich hide wealth and avoid taxes through shell companies[3]. The third is the Catholic Church sexual abuse crisis: in 2002 the investigative team of *The Boston Globe* exposed how the Archdiocese of Boston had for decades systematically shielded clergy who serially abused children, and the thousands of pages of diocesan files released under court order ultimately forced the resignation of Cardinal Law, one of the most powerful prelates in the United States[4]. The three differ in domain, scale, and type of conduct, yet they are structurally isomorphic: exclusive access (wealth, power, holy orders, secrecy) sustains the mutual binding within the group, and when the systemic crime finally surfaces, the reckoning often stops at the level of the individual—a few scapegoats fall, allowing the group to renarrate a systemic problem as the isolated transgression of individuals, so that the structure of impunity survives.

In the language of the Macro-Cognitive Accounting Framework (MCAF) of Chapter 3, this is the typical form of the narrative leverage ratio ($\Omega = \phi/\|L\|$) entering the liquidation phase while the liquidation is "personalized"; it is also an instance of Hypothesis Five (the topological isomorphism of historical scenarios). The claim here is a weak claim: the three cases share one and the same dynamic structure, but it is not claimed that this structure is scale-independent—the scale gap between a transnational network and the Archdiocese of Boston may introduce new dynamic features (such as cross-jurisdictional impunity mechanisms). Structural isomorphism does not

[2]Following the passage of the *Epstein Files Transparency Act* (H.R.4405, 119th Congress), the U.S. Department of Justice released in bulk over 3 million pages of documents, more than 2,000 videos, and 180,000 images on January 30, 2026 (U.S. Department of Justice, 2026). An independent UN human rights expert panel concluded in a joint statement in February 2026 that the files are "suggestive of the existence of a global criminal enterprise," and that a number of the patterns of victimization "may reasonably meet the legal threshold of crimes against humanity" (OHCHR, 2026). Aside from Ghislaine Maxwell, who was convicted in 2021 and sentenced to 20 years in 2022, as of the NPR report, the Department of Justice had brought no new criminal charges against any other close associate (NPR, 2026). U.S. Deputy Attorney General Todd Blanche stated in a January 30, 2026 interview with Fox News (the same day as the bulk release) that "in none of these communications, even when doing his best to disparage President Trump, did Epstein suggest President Trump had done anything criminal or had any inappropriate contact with any of his victims" (Singman, 2026). This records only the executive branch's public judgment in this particular case. Establishing a broader mechanism in which the system shifts from "covering up the problem" to "redefining the problem" would require continuous process evidence showing changes in disclosure rules, investigative scope, responsibility standards, and which nodes were thereby removed from the scope of accountability.

[3]On the Panama Papers, see Obermayer & Obermaier (2016) and Bernstein (2017): the 2016 leak of 11.5 million documents from the Mossack Fonseca law firm exposed offshore tax evasion and money laundering by a global elite, yet led to few prosecutions of the network as a whole. The apex of impunity came in June 2024: a Panamanian court acquitted all 28 defendants of the firm (including co-founder Jürgen Mossack) of money laundering, on the grounds that the electronic evidence the prosecution had obtained from servers did not follow the legally required "chain of custody" (The New York Times, 2024; ICIJ, 2026a); the other co-founder, Ramón Fonseca, had died earlier that year, and the charges against him were dropped. Over the decade, those who entered the criminal accountability pipeline were individual politicians and individual firm personnel—Pakistan's former prime minister Sharif was sentenced to ten years in prison in 2018, and former firm partner Zollinger was convicted of aiding and abetting tax evasion by Cologne's regional court in April 2026 and received a suspended prison sentence of one year and nine months, with a probationary period of three years (ICIJ, 2026b; dpa, 2026)—rather than a systemic reckoning with the offshore network. Meanwhile, ICIJ's data team estimates that at least US$1.3 billion recouped by authorities internationally can be directly attributed to the investigation, a figure that is likely an undercount (ICIJ, 2026a). The tightening at the institutional level, cross-border tax recovery, and divergent individual-level accountability across jurisdictions coexist—the reckoning stops at the level of individuals while the systemic structure of the offshore network survives—which is precisely the emblematic presentation of "the problem personalized, the system surviving."

[4]On the American epicenter of the Catholic Church sexual abuse crisis, see the Investigative Staff of *The Boston Globe* (2002/2016), *Betrayal: The Crisis in the Catholic Church*; the account of Cardinal Law's resignation at the end of 2002 is drawn from the updated edition's afterword: in January 2002, taking as its point of departure the case of Fr. John Geoghan, who serially abused children across the 1960s–80s, the paper exposed how the Archdiocese of Boston had long reassigned accused clergy elsewhere to cover up their crimes. The thousands of pages of diocesan files released under court order documented decades of systematic cover-up and ultimately forced Cardinal Law to resign as Archbishop of Boston at the end of 2002. The Roman Curia once treated this as "the American problem," yet the same pattern was subsequently documented across numerous U.S. dioceses (see also Frawley-O'Dea & Goldner, 2007) and in many countries: the French independent commission CIASE's *Final Report* (2021) estimated that approximately 216,000 people had been sexually abused as minors by Catholic clergy or members of religious orders between 1950 and 2020; Australia's Royal Commission into Institutional Responses to Child Sexual Abuse (2013–2017; Final Report released December 2017, comprising 17 volumes and 189 recommendations) went beyond any single church to systematically scrutinize decades of institutional failure across many kinds of institutions, the Catholic Church among them. The same pattern, transnational and spanning generations, shows that the problem was personalized onto individual offenders while the systemic structure of impunity survived.

require isomorphism in scale. For Hsu's theory, these networks provide material for comparing exclusive access, the instrumental treatment of others, and the displacement of responsibility, but they do not yet establish that all are products of individualism pushed to its extreme. A continuous pathway from organizational splitting to greater exclusiveness and then to arrangements of impunity must be traced separately in each case. Until that is done, this chapter treats them as suggestive comparisons of mechanisms, not as verified instances of one cultural cause.

### 4.5.4 Summary of Criteria

The contemporary state of Hsu's diagnoses at five levels:

| Level of Judgment | Hsu's Original Judgment | Contemporary Data | Corresponding State | Strength of Evidence |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Crime rate trend | American society faced an unusual and growing problem of adolescent crime throughout the country | Down 71% between 1993 and 2022 (Bureau of Justice Statistics [BJS] National Crime Victimization Survey) | Not directly testable: overall victimization and adolescent offending use different measures | Strong source for the statistic; not a direct test of the original claim (see Pew Research Center, 2024) |
| Homeostatic compensation structure | The self-reliant turn to clubs and non-human objects | Nonprofits grew from 1.38 million (2003) to 2.0 million (2023)—proxy indicator; loneliness as epidemic; social capital inverted U-curve descending | Descriptively compatible: organization counts and depth of participation are different measures | Relatively strong descriptive data; theoretical correspondence remains to be tested (Putnam, 2000/2020; Hertz, 2021; Statista, 2024; McKeever, 2015) |
| Worldview dualization | "Immutable inner world" leading to irreconcilability | Affective polarization increased; two-party overlap vanished; interpersonal trust fell from 46% to about 30% | Descriptively compatible | Strong descriptive data; moderate support for the proposed cultural mechanism (Holliday, Lelkes & Westwood, 2024; Twenge, Campbell & Carter, 2014; Hertz, 2021; Turchin, 2023) |

| Level of Judgment | Hsu's Original Judgment | Contemporary Data | Corresponding State | Strength of Evidence |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Club elite-ization | Exclusive cliques control club social life | Epstein network—transnational elite impunity | Suggestive correspondence | Case facts can be checked; cultural attribution remains to be tested |
| Legitimacy base | Individualism-conformity paradox erodes institutional foundation | Congressional trust around 10%; extreme distress up from 3.6% (1993) to 6.4% (2019); executive unilateralism accelerating | Pressure on procedural trust; the evidence does not locate a failure threshold | Relatively strong descriptive data; threshold and causal mapping remain to be tested (Brenan, 2025; Blanchflower & Oswald, 2020; Turchin, 2023) |

Four decades later, the U.S. Surgeon General's advisory has identified loneliness and social isolation as serious public-health concerns. This is compatible with Hsu's judgment about the importance of durable intimate bonds, but it is neither an official endorsement of Hsu's theory nor evidence by itself that rugged individualism caused the crisis. The materials in this section show that affect-layer and role-layer indicators may diverge; whether this structural explanation outperforms alternatives remains a question for further comparative research.

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## §5 The State: The Historical Extension of Psychosocial Homeostasis and the Modulator of Non-Human Substitution

### §5.1 The Political Power of the State and the Theory of the Dominant Kinship Dyad

In *The Confucian-Legalist State*, Zhao Dingxin argues that political power differs from the other three power sources in that it is both coercive and emanates from a single center, and possesses performance-based legitimacy that the other three power sources do not possess (Zhao Dingxin, 2015/2022). This book accordingly summarizes: these characteristics of political power cannot be reduced to products of economic exchange or interpersonal relations. The Confucian-Legalist state of the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods was the product of military competition: the survival game among feudal states, where winners and losers were clear-cut, selected for Legalist-type instrumental-rational state capacity, and Confucianism provided ideological legitimacy for it (Zhao Dingxin, 2015/2022).

But Zhao's logic of competition leaves a question unanswered: given the same competition, why did traditional China move at the end of the Warring States period toward a unified traditional empire, while Europe, after prolonged military competition, remained a multi-state system? Zhao's answer emphasizes social structure—Spring and Autumn China had only two types of social actors—the state and the aristocracy—and Legalist reforms faced extremely low resistance; medieval Europe had four types of social actors—states, the aristocracy, churches, and the urban bourgeoisie—competing and checking each other (Zhao Dingxin, 2015/2022). This book proposes a testable **governance-cost hypothesis** between Zhao's account of state formation and Hsu's

description of relations to authority: the centripetal, father-son-axis worldview described by Hsu secured for the government of traditional China greater respect and unquestioning obedience; at the same time, the low-contact condition summed up in the saying "Heaven is high and the emperor far away," together with the clan's assumption of part of grassroots order, may have reduced some costs of direct administrative penetration and routine order maintenance (Hsu, 1963, 1981). This book further hypothesizes that the centrifugal orientation and active-consent requirement associated with the husband-wife axis may raise the costs of legitimating centralized governance and coordinating plural actors. Zhao explains **how** the state forms, while Hsu's materials offer clues to a possible structural affinity between state forms and relational configurations. The cost relationship stated here is a new inference of this book, not a conclusion already demonstrated by either author.

- **In father-son-axis homeostasis, the traditional empire has a structural affinity with this ideal type**—under the testable governance-cost hypothesis above, the father-son axis may reduce some costs of direct administrative penetration and grassroots order maintenance in a unified traditional empire (passive obedience + the clan's role in grassroots order), while the traditional empire in turn reinforces the institutional carriers of the father-son axis (civil service examinations, patrilineal law, and ritual system). "State-family isomorphism" does not mean that the family is enlarged to become the state—the state has its own formative logic—but that there exists a positive-feedback cost affinity between the father-son axis configuration and the traditional empire form. Legitimacy comes from "care" (the outward extension of paternal duty); the form of power is hierarchical; the temporal horizon is ultra-long-term. The default position of the state modulation end leans toward the defense side—inclined to limit external forces that could disrupt homeostasis.
- **In husband-wife-axis homeostasis, the state is understood as the institutionalization of contract**—a cooperative framework voluntarily established by free individuals. Under the testable governance-cost hypothesis above, the centrifugal orientation of the husband-wife axis may raise the costs of legitimating centralized governance and coordinating plural actors; decentralized checks and balances may therefore have a stronger structural affinity with this ideal type, but are not the only possible outcome determined by the husband-wife axis alone. Legitimacy comes from "consent" (the outward extension of volition); the form of power is constrained; the temporal horizon is short-to-medium term. The default position of the state modulation end leans toward neutrality or the projection side—inclined not to intervene in the free action of individuals and enterprises.

Neither default position is absolute, but they represent the "zero point"—the position to which the state will spontaneously return in the absence of special forces pushing it. Of course, any contemporary realization of either homeostatic ideal must pass through the mediation of concrete political-economic conditions—the interest configurations, institutional inertia, and key actors' strategic choices of each historical moment will alter the outcome. The psychosocial homeostasis theory argues for ideal-type directions, not deterministic outcomes.

### §5.2 The Regulatory Fork: The Contemporary Folding of Homeostatic Ideals

In the 2020s, China and the United States have followed visibly different paths in regulating algorithmic platforms. Since 2021, China has intensively introduced regulations: the Internet Information Service Algorithmic Recommendation Management Provisions (published December 2021, effective March 2022), the Data Security Law (effective September 2021), the Anti-Monopoly Guidelines of the Anti-Monopoly Commission of the State Council on the Platform Economy (issued February 2021), and the Regulations on the Protection of Minors in

Cyberspace (effective January 2024) (Cyberspace Administration of China et al., 2021; Standing Committee of the National People's Congress, 2021; Anti-Monopoly Commission of the State Council, 2021; State Council, 2023). Federal action in the United States has instead proceeded through targeted legislation. As of the finalization of this book in early October 2026, the TAKE IT DOWN Act had become law in May 2025, requiring covered platforms to establish a notice-and-removal process for nonconsensual intimate visual depictions; the Kids Internet and Digital Safety Act (KIDS Act) passed the House in June 2026 and was referred to the Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation in July, but had not become law (U.S. Congress, 2025, 2026).

This chapter advances a testable interpretive hypothesis: the combination of American rugged individualism and the husband-wife-axis configuration may raise the justificatory cost of restricting platforms' freedom of action.

Hsu (1981) held that America's individual-centered orientation originated in English individualism, but immediately stressed that the two had diverged substantially: in his analysis, a qualified individualism with a qualified equality prevailed in England, whereas the United States elevated self-reliance together with economic, social, and political equality into an unrestricted ideal. He also observed that settlers in Australia, New Zealand, and Canada were self-sufficient to varying degrees and came largely from societies where individualism was dominant, yet did not develop a way of life identical or even very similar to that of the United States. Hsu later characterized English individualism as limited by royalty, aristocracy, class, church tradition, and local community, while explicitly describing eighteenth- and nineteenth-century American individualism as more rugged (Hsu, 1983).

Contemporary regulatory trajectories are consistent with this distinction, but cannot by themselves establish cultural causation. Under the United Kingdom's Online Safety Act, platform duties to protect children have been enforced since July 25, 2025. Building on the regulation-making power conferred by section 70 of the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026, the UK government announced in June 2026 that it would bar children under 16 from certain social media services. As of the finalization of this book, this age restriction was not yet in force: the first secondary regulations were expected to be laid before the end of 2026, with implementation expected in spring 2027; messaging, educational, e-commerce, and music-streaming services were intended to be excluded (Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, 2025, 2026; United Kingdom, 2026). Australia's social-media minimum-age regime became law in 2024 and, from December 10, 2025, has required age-restricted platforms to take reasonable steps to prevent users under 16 from holding accounts (Australia, 2024).

The British and Australian paths serve here to identify the specificity of American rugged individualism, not as counterexamples drawn from a generic category of "individual-centered societies." The European Union is a supranational institutional structure, not a single cultural configuration in Hsu's sense, and its Digital Services Act has applied in full since February 17, 2024. Article 28 requires online platforms accessible to minors to put in place appropriate and proportionate measures to ensure a high level of privacy, safety, and security for minors, and prohibits profiling-based advertising when a platform is aware with reasonable certainty that the recipient is a minor. The European Commission's 2025 guidelines on the protection of minors further recommend private-by-default accounts, adjustments to recommender systems to reduce harmful content and rabbit-hole risks, disabling by default features that contribute to excessive use, and safeguards for AI chatbots integrated into online platforms. The guidelines serve as a reference point for assessing compliance with Article 28, but following them is voluntary and does not automatically guarantee compliance (European Parliament

& Council of the European Union, 2022; European Commission, 2025). The EU is therefore used here to calibrate the timing, instruments, and intensity of institutional intervention in the protection of minors, not as a single cultural-configuration sample. These measures differ in object, intensity, and legal status and cannot be collapsed into a single category of "belated passive response."

### §5.3 Different Modulations of Non-Human Substitution

Facing the non-human substitution argued in §3–§4, the effectiveness of the two state modulation ends depends on the substitution pathway.

- **Chinese-style modulation (direct interruption of projection-side variables)** Effective under conditions where: substitution occurs through identifiable channels (specific applications can be banned, specific algorithms restricted); the sunk cost of substitution has not yet locked in. Limited or ineffective where changes in civilizational defaults uniformly cover the information environment and regulators lack independent comparisons and effective proxies, or where they can identify the change but cannot locate and intervene in its common generating mechanisms. The difficulty concerns evidence and enforcement conditions, not the inherent invisibility of second-order change; interventions in recommender rules, product features, and platform duties must still be assessed in the specific setting.
- **American-style modulation (reliance on market and judicial ex-post correction)** Effective under conditions where: the damage is quantifiable and there are identifiable victims (compensation can be pursued through litigation); the causal chain of damage is short and clear. Ineffective under conditions where: the damage is gradual, diffuse, and difficult to attribute (attention fragmentation cannot be pursued through litigation); the causal chain of damage is longer than the statute of limitations.

The types of blind spots the two modes face regarding the problem of non-human substitution differ: one blind spot of Chinese-style modulation is gradual substitution for which independent comparisons or enforceable points of intervention are lacking; the blind spot of the American style is the unattributability of damage—gradual, diffuse harm cannot be pursued through litigation.

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## §6 Mutual Translation and Conclusion

### §6.1 Semi-Modernity

§1.4 emphasizes that existing cultural configurations affect how technological change is absorbed and institutionalized. The contemporary materials in §4 are only compatible with this claim and cannot by themselves establish a one-way causal direction. Twenge's (2023) Technology Model of Generations emphasizes the reverse direction—that technology makes the expansion of individualism possible—suggesting a feedback relation: existing cultural configurations shape the adoption and institutionalization of technology, while technology and institutions can subsequently reshape relational structures and meta-audit capacity. In MCAF terms, cultural configuration as the initial distribution of meta-audit capacity affects what kind of legitimacy base develops, without excluding subsequent feedback from the legitimacy base and technological environment to meta-audit capacity. This leads into Hsu's 1981 diagnosis:

> "The term modernity has been naively defined by our present-day social scientists in terms of

> machines and organizational efficiency for economic and political purposes. Even where they speak of the quality of human life they still measure modernity by such things as mobility or consumption patterns. We have to realize that that is no more than semimodernity at best. Freedom from want does not lead to freedom from interpersonal anxiety and hostility." (Hsu, 1981)

Meta-formula translation: the projection side has entered the exponential expansion zone, while the affect audit dimension of the defense side has never been "modernized"—because it cannot be modernized by technological means. The "semi" lies in a different place for each civilization. For America: the material half has been achieved; the interpersonal half has not. For China: the interpersonal half has a foundation but with limits; the material half was long absent—rapidly filled over the past forty years, but whether the filling process itself is altering the initial configuration of meta-audit capacity requires tracking with contemporary evidence.

### §6.2 Four Criteria

This chapter hands over to subsequent chapters four **testable structural hypotheses**.

1. **Causal direction.** The initial configuration of meta-audit capacity influences the formation of the legitimacy base; once technologies and institutions have formed, they may also reshape relational structures and meta-audit capacity in return. Institutional change does not automatically reshape cultural configuration, but the feedback direction cannot be excluded in advance.
2. **Orthogonality.** The precise operation of role audit cannot compensate for the decay of affect audit. The perfection of procedural legitimacy cannot compensate for the absence of the affect layer. Hsu's most precise formulation: psychoanalysis is an artificial kidney, not health (Hsu, 1983).
3. **Dynamic type.** In this book's ideal-type analysis, the desire-type is more likely to generate a narrative iterative engine consisting of intensity-seeking, waning interest, and the refreshment of substitute objects. The reciprocity-type is not thereby logically excluded from narrative iteration; rather, the father-son-axis configuration examined here does not rely on that engine as its dominant mechanism of relational maintenance. The typical substitution pathways for the two dominant dynamics therefore differ—primarily parasitism and acceleration for the desire-type, and primarily bypassing bodily presence and the conditions of obligation fulfillment for the reciprocity-type. If an iterative engine of equivalent structure and strength is observed in relations dominated by reciprocity, this division of pathways must be narrowed.
4. **Semi-modernity.** The "modernization" of the projection side does not equal the "modernization" of the defense side. The extremely rapid growth of performance legitimacy can coexist with the continuous atrophy of affect audit without contradiction.

### §6.3 The Unity of Statics and Dynamics: From Anchoring to Substitution, Toward "Globalism Based on Time, Not on the Clock"

The static anchoring of §1–§2 and the dynamic substitution of §3–§5, taken together, yield a structural necessity: mutual translation. When the projection side enters the exponential zone, the vulnerability lines of the two homeostatic ideals are activated differently yet simultaneously; the audit of each civilization alone is no longer sufficient to identify systemic risks—each must draw on the perspective of the other's configuration to mutually illuminate blind spots.

This is rooted globalism—globalism based on time, not on the clock. Rooted, because mutual translation takes

each civilization's own direct contact with the real as its starting point—homeostatic ideals, intimate relationships, embodied experience—requiring no one to pull up their roots; globalism, because in the era of exponential expansion of the projection side, the audit of any single root alone is no longer enough. Its antithesis is rootless globalism—globalism based on the clock: using a single set of clock readings to cover all civilizations, mistaking the global uniformity of readings for the global completion of calibration. Its contemporary forms include, but are not limited to: the platform monometric governance under Silicon Valley's discourse of "connecting the world" (user count, engagement time, retention rate as the sole metrics), and the development discourse that treats a particular institutional template as a universal solution. von Neumann (1955) had already diagnosed the asymmetry between technological expansion and geopolitical containers (the initial unfolding of this asymmetric structure appears in Chapter 3, §0.2); the urgency of mutual translation is this book's inference from that asymmetry. When the projection side enters the exponential zone, no civilization can complete the audit alone.

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## Appendices

### §A.1 Japan (Iemoto): Role Audit and Affect Audit Are Not Separated

Japan is not a simple replica of the father-son axis. Hsu, in Chapter 20 of *Rugged Individualism Reconsidered*, provides a detailed argument for Japan's uniqueness (Hsu, 1983).

His core finding, restated in this book's terms: the Japanese *iemoto* system carries both role relations and affective bonds within one structure, potentially supplying relational conditions for both forms of audit; their coexistence alone does not establish that role audit and affect audit are both satisfied. Non-heir sons are released from their natal kinship, but instead of becoming "independent individuals," they enter an *iemoto*. The *oyabun-kobun* (parent-child) relationship within the *iemoto* is both functional (the superior is responsible for guidance and work placement) and affective (the superior "kindly (like a parent) takes care of his men" [Kato, 1966, quoted in Hsu, 1983]). Leaving one's *iemoto*-like company is an "embarrassing and unhappy affair similar in atmosphere to marital divorce" (Rohlen, 1974, quoted in Hsu, 1983)—this shows that *iemoto*-style organizations carry not only functional significance but also affective attachment; whether that attachment supports what this book calls affect audit depends on whether the relation permits disagreement and repair.

The *iemoto* shows that role relations and affective bonds can be carried by the same organization without the former being understood as compensation for the latter. This does not violate the functional orthogonality hypothesis of §2.2: functions that are not directly interchangeable may coexist within one relationship, but effective affect audit still requires the conditions for disagreement and repair specified above. Japan's *ringi* system—where middle management drafts, colleagues deliberate, and each level affixes seals—can be examined as an institutional form of collective deliberation: the loyal young person is responsible for using his brains, and the seniority-based hierarchy guarantees security; both operate simultaneously within the same process. The cost is extremely high exclusivity: the boundaries between *iemoto* are as rigid as caste. The Japanese "did not develop universalism any more than the Chinese" (Hsu, 1983).

### §A.2 India (Caste/Mother-Son Axis): The Flight of Meta-Audit Capacity Toward the Supernatural

Hsu classifies India under the "unilateral dependence" pattern (Hsu, 1963). The intrinsic attributes of the mother-son relationship—dependence, diffuseness, libidinality—diffuse throughout the entire society, making caste "a

refuge from the diffuseness generated by the supernatural orientation of the culture" (Hsu, 1963). The fissiparousness of caste—India is estimated to have more than 26,000 sub-castes (Hsu, 1963)—stands in extreme contrast to the cohesiveness of the Chinese clan—the number of actually existing Chinese surnames is less than a quarter of those on ancient lists (Hsu, 1963). Hsu argues in Chapter 8 of *Clan, Caste, and Club*: the caste system is the manifestation of the internal contradiction of the supernaturally-centered world—facing a diffuse condition of nonattachment, people protect themselves by shutting themselves behind the closed walls of caste; yet the impulse to satisfy social needs cannot be enclosed within any particular walls (Hsu, 1963).

Hsu's analysis of India is less developed than his analyses of China, the United States, and Japan; the predictive power of the "mother-son axis" framework for contemporary India is limited. This chapter uses it as a contrast rather than a full configuration.

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